presented a chance to catch up on the news. Most Soviet newspapers did not publish on Sundays, with the notable exception of the leading party daily, *Pravda*, which appeared seven days a week. That morning its front page featured the text of Khrushchev's letter to President Kennedy offering the Turkey-Cuba missile swap. A quotation from a recent appeal by Bertrand Russell indicated the guilty party. The famous philosopher had written that if Kennedy proved unwilling to come to an agreement with the Soviet Union, the result might be an unprecedented disaster for humanity.[2]

Judging by *Pravda*, the Soviet people were fully supportive of their wise leader and his policies. The foreman of a communist shock brigade in Leningrad, S. Vitchenko, allegedly told a *Pravda* reporter: "N. S. Khrushchev is right, a thousand times right, in calling on the president of the USA at this bleak and alarming hour to show prudence and negotiate. Good sense, and not the psychosis of nuclear war, should triumph." The quotation continued: "You think, Mr. President, that Cuba is a threat to you! But are the nuclear installations in Turkey not menacingly directed against our land? So stop your saber-rattling at last, sit down at the negotiating table, and do not bring humanity to the verge of military catastrophe!" Such was the key message that Khrushchev's propaganda machine was now delivering at home and abroad.[3]

As always, the Soviet papers were reporting yesterday's news. Reports arriving in Moscow from Washington and Havana after 1:00 a.m. local time indicated that things were spinning out of control. Not only was Castro directly confronting the Americans by ordering his troops to fire at their aircraft without asking Moscow's opinion, but Moscow's own commanders were joining in, having shot down an American plane. The shooting war in the Caribbean had already broken out, and Khrushchev had to react without delay. But it was Sunday. He would not see his minister of defense until late morning.[4]

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MARSHAL RODION MALINOVSKY REPORTED TO KHRUSHCHEV on the latest developments in Cuba sometime after 10:45 a.m.—the time indicated on his